

are already in double digit versions, Debian has just reached a version number of 5. Despite the focus on reliability, an approach that both Slackware and Gentoo used, Debian still supports one of the largest software repositories around. In fact, there are unofficial repositories, for installing software that does not entirely fit into Debian's strict requirements of free and open source software.

Due to the immense size of the repositories, a lot of distros are derived from Debian. Any distro that uses the .deb packages, is a derivative of Debian. Knoppix and Ubuntu are the major ones, and both these distros are widely used and well known, even having a whole bunch of derivative distros of their own.

The entire distribution can be downloaded as 35 CDs or 5 DVDs. Since just downloading the distribution takes up a considerable amount of resources, most people who actually download and install Debian go for the net install version. This installs the basic operating system, after which users will have to install packages from the internet. The netinstall CD is just short of 700 MB, and this is in fact, not a bad idea. Most users will use just a fraction of the 25,000+ software supported, and a fair share of these software are small and easy to download and install. Debian shies away from having "versions" of the distro, and instead uses something known as "melds". Every installation of Debian grows into a "meld" over time. A "meld" is a Debian build with a selection of packages suitable for a particular purpose, as in network administration, education or gaming.

5.5.1 Installing Debian

There are two basic approaches to install Debian, the difference is very superficial. Place the disc in the tray, and restart the machine. This is the screen that you should see:

The options available are Install, Graphical Install, Advanced Options and Help. Choose either the Install or the Graphical Install options. The steps in both the installations is essentially the same. We will be showing steps from the graphical installation. An interesting feature in the installation for Debian, is that it allows you to take screenshots, like the OpenSUSE installer. However, you do not need to go into the command line and mount a drive to do this, there is a button on the installer itself. Next, you will have to